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by OnceABlueMoon

Summary

The sun is setting. The clouds are the very same pink color as the cotton candy Bow had brought her earlier and how unfair, him doing something so sweet, so romantic, as to bring her the sky when he has no idea what he's doing to her. A flush creeps down her cheeks and she's so glad she's alone because if Catra or Adora saw this, she would never live it down.

Glimmer breathes, watching the cotton candy clouds and the orange sky behind them, the air getting colder, helping her with getting a cooler head.

She likes Bow. But is she sure enough to do something about it? She'd love to just barge over right now and tell him, but… She's been learning to think things through better lately. Her impulsivity is all fine on its own, but a nation shouldn't have to bear the consequences of her sudden decisions and neither should a relationship. She swallows.

Glimmer tips her head back, laying down and closing her eyes, letting her legs dangle off the edge of the roof as she tries to imagine kissing Bow. The idea is nice, getting that close to him, but she already does that regularly, and cuddling him is amazing, but the part where their lips touch - that's a problem.

Notes

Disclaimer: I don't own She-Ra and the Princesses of Power.

It’s a regular Wednesday and Glimmer’s in the throne room having audiences with anyone in Bright Moon who has a problem that requires royal attention when it happens. While the men and women in front of her keep talking about their border dispute, she catches sight of Bow. He’s slipping out of the side door, preoccupied with his burden - in one hand he’s carefully holding onto a candied apple just so that the sticky part won’t touch his hand, in the other he has her very favorite: cotton candy. His eyes flit over the still ongoing audience and then go up, up, up, towards the throne to meet hers. Glimmer, in a good mood, winks. Bow smiles back, and Glimmer’s heart just goes *boom.*

By the time the audience ends, she’s still not entirely sure what caused it. Her heart does it again when Bow approaches with the sweets. "They had a stand in the town square!" he exclaims. "I didn’t think you had time to go today, so I’d just have to bring them to you."

"You didn’t have them just tow the cart over here?" Glimmer asks, "Tsk, tsk, Bow, and here I thought you finally understood to take advantage of your spot as the Queen’s right hand."

Bow snorts as he hands her the cotton candy. "I think *you* might have been spending a little too much time with Catra if you’re talking like that." His eyes soften. "I’m glad she’s settling in well."

Glimmer nods. "Hmm, though if I open Adora’s bedroom *one* more time to find them fooling around…" She takes a bite out of the cotton candy. It melts on her tongue, sugary and pink.

Bow nudges her until she leans enough to the side so he can crawl onto the throne beside her, snug and warm, throwing an arm around her. "I can see it already. A new royal decree! ‘One must put a sock on the door handle when amorously occupied’. It will be shouted all over town by the heralds for ages."

Glimmer giggles, fingers and mouth sticky, her lips sticking together a little. He offers her a bite of the candied apple, sweet

on the outside, sour within. Fresh, new, and yet old and familiar. Leaning into Bow's side, she can't be much bothered to figure out what that was earlier. He's here and that means life is good.

Warmth fills her chest.

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Later, when the sour taste of the candied apple has long left her mouth but the sweetness of it is still in her heart, Glimmer contemplates what happened. What a weird thing, for a heart to do, that double beat so fast it felt like it was working overtime without any physical exhaustion at all. Seeing Bow's dazzling smile made her feel a little dizzy and she'd go to the royal physician, except it sounds familiar and-

Oh.

A heart that beats faster, a smile that makes her dizzy, a warmth in her chest when he's near. Maybe this is more than friendship. Maybe this is a crush. Maybe it's more than that - something that's lived in her heart for a long time but she's just never recognized before. Glimmer doesn't really know what to do with that. Which she doesn't like, because acting is better than sitting still and she's already been doing an awful lot of that lately. Huffing, she teleports up to the roof.

The sun is setting. The clouds are the very same pink color as the cotton candy Bow had brought her earlier and how *unfair,* him doing something so sweet, so romantic, as to bring her the sky when he has no idea what he's doing to her. A flush creeps down her cheeks and she's so glad she's alone because if Catra or Adora saw this, she would never live it down.

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What Glimmer would *like* to say the problem with kissing Bow would be is this: it would upset the delicate balance their friendship has gone through before, mainly with 'how to share a friend with other people' and so on. The truth about the problem with kissing Bow is this: Bow is very attractive, his lips look positively sumptuous and her heart beats faster whenever he smiles, but she doesn't want to kiss him. Not really.

It feels like she's bitten into the candied apple, through its sweet exterior into the sour heart.

"Hey, room for one more?"

Glimmer shoots up at Catra's throaty voice, tumbling over the edge of the roof. For a second, air rushes past her, before she teleports back up. "Holy shizzles - we *really* should put a bell on you one of these days!"

Catra wrinkles her nose at her as she pads over the roof towards her. "I'd like to see you *try,* Sparkles."

Glimmer tilts her chin up. "Think I can't do it? Teleportation, remember?"

Catra lifts her lip, showing off her bare teeth. "If you'd like some claws all over your face, yes."

Glimmer huffs haughtily. "Nobody likes a startled cat."

At that, Catra starts to laugh, motioning toward the edge of the roof. "Nobody likes a startled queen either."

They look at each other for a beat before they start laughing. Glimmer sits back down again and Catra curls up beside her in a way that makes her look like she doesn't have any bones. It's freaky, but everything about Catra is, at least a little. It's what makes her fun.

Catra doesn't expect to see a queen when she looks at Glimmer. She's all insults a four-year-old could think up - venom that lost its sharp edge years ago, familiar and childish by now. Though it isn't that long ago they faced each other on the battlefield, being held captive by Horde Prime together changed something in their relationship irrevocably. Even a familiar enemy was nice there, their insults reminding them of home. Even now there's no war anymore, they like the comfort of that old routine.

Tonight, Glimmer breaks it. "What's it like, telling your best friend you're in love with them?"

Catra blinks. Glimmer can't take it seriously, because Catra blinks like a cat, but she doesn't dare laugh at her right now. Not when the answer is so important to her.

"I didn't. I just kissed her, then it was implied and *Adora* had to say it first." Catra looks unbearably smug about it.

Glimmer clenches her fist. "But what if you didn't want to kiss Adora? What if you just wanted to wake up to her face every morning and never ever touch her below the waist at all?"

The sun has gone down and Catra's features are hard to make out, but even in the low light coming from the palace windows below, Glimmer can make out her frown. "That would make the implying harder, yeah. Why are you asking *me* anyway? I'm not exactly the expert, even if me kissing Adora *did* save the world." Catra preens.

"Who else would I ask? Mermista and Sea Hawk? I'm not even sure *if* they function, let alone *how.* I don't think I really want to know either."

Catra shrugs. "Scorpia's been getting pretty kissy with Perfuma lately, hasn't she? Why not ask her?"

Glimmer clenches her fist harder at that, her nails cutting half-moons into her palms. "The kissing is the problem in the first place! Catra- Adora said my mom told us to take care of each other. But I can't even figure out if Bow-" she stops talking. "I can't even figure out what *I* want."

"You? Not knowing what you want?" Catra throws her head back and cackles. "Come up with a better excuse, Sparkles. You know perfectly well what you want. You always do. The question is what you're going to do about it, and I can't help you with that. Don't feel like it either. Put your big girl panties on and figure it out."

Catra stands up, Glimmer sticks out her tongue and makes an ugly face at her, and then she's alone on the roof again. Her feelings roil about in her stomach like a ship upon the rowdy waves of the sea, a storm surrounding it. Shaking her head, she teleports back into her room, getting ready for bed.

Staring at the ceiling doesn't help her much. It only makes her think more and as Catra said, her problem right now is acting. Should she just get up and stop wasting her time? Just barge up to Bow's door and tell him? Sure, it sounds like a good plan, but a lot of things sound like a good plan at three am, and they often don't pack out like she wants them to. This is too important to be one of them.

Their history is so long; they've been together as friends forever. Is that a con or a pro in this situation? Glimmer's not so sure all of a sudden.

Bow grew up with twelve siblings - getting Glimmer's full attention after a household that packed must've felt like a drug. Is that

what this is? Has Bow been staying with her all these years because he was simply too beholden to that initial feeling of connection over their mutual loneliness? Glimmer would hate that.

She shakes her head. It's a silly thought anyway because Bow is one of the most honest people she knows. He'd never pretend to be her friend if he wasn't, he cares for other people's feelings too much. But the hour is late and the night is dark and she can't help but think - what if?

She doesn't get much sleep that night.

---

"Glimmer, Glimmer!" Bow runs into her office, "They heard you liked the cotton candy yesterday and put up a whole fair in front of the castle in your honor!"

Glimmer's eyes widen before she fist pumps. "Yes! I knew being Queen had to have *some* benefits!" Then she looks down at her paperwork and pulls a face. "Ugh, if we lock the office, they won't notice I'm gone, right?"

Bow taps his chin, keeping up a serious facade. "I don't know, but do we care?"

Glimmer nods imperiously. "My subjects are calling for me. As Queen, it is only right I heed their call and skip work in order to party!" She takes the arm Bow is warmly holding out and teleports them both down to the square in front of the palace.

The fair is beautiful. There are lights everywhere, but most aren't lit yet: they're likely there for later tonight when darkness falls and they will be as magical as the rest of the fair already is. There are rides, most powered by magic, some powered by tech. A fairy wheel, complete with wings on the back of the carts as they lift into the air, is at the back, a mini haunted house, a roller coaster, a teacup ride and even some real horses for the kids to ride on. Swift Wind is cheerfully leading them as a host of children look at him with wide, awed eyes.

Bow grabs her hand and off they go. They pass the bumper cars, where Adora and Catra and trying to knock each other off their car, all the children around being held back by somewhat grumpy parents. Glimmer can't help but grin at their competitiveness. Bow leads her through the crowd, never letting go of her hand, and suddenly she's all too aware of just how warm it is. Her hand starts to sweat and she wants to let go of his hand so he doesn't notice, but she also *doesn't* ever want to let go of his hand.

They go on the teacups ride. Bow doesn't let go. Glimmer begins to worry. They've been holding hands since they were kids, but never this long. Is he just casually holding hands? Or is this meant to be a date? Are they dating? No, they can't be, Glimmer didn't even realize she liked him before yesterday. Does he even think of her like that? Is he going to kiss her? She doesn't want that!

As the teacup spins, Glimmer's mood spins out of control too.

"Hey, you alright?" Bow asks as he stands up to leave the ride.

"Yeah." Glimmer chokes out, fanning herself. "Just a little dizzy!"

It's a lie. It's a big fat lie and Glimmer *never* lies to Bow. What is becoming of her?!

She stalks forward, his hand still in hers as she gets out of the ride as quickly as possible. The next stand has sweets, surrounded by twinkling lights and brightly colored signs. She sees the candied apples right next to the cotton candy and decides she can't let this go on any longer: no sourness should be left to linger like this in her heart. Not when Bow is her best friend, when he is the person she values most in this world, the one she wants always, whether as a friend or as something more. Something needs to be done.

She tugs him in between two tents, where they at least have some privacy. The sound around them fades away, the music and the noise from the crowd in the distance now. She takes a deep breath, lets go of his hand and starts to talk: "Bow, I don't want

to kiss you." She slaps a hand in front of her mouth. "Oh - that was not how I wanted this conversation to go. Maybe I should have thought about what I was going to say? I'm rambling now. I don't *like* rambling. Bow, please just say something!"

Bow slows the whole process down as he always does, with his logical mind, his peaceful soul, and says: "Wait. I thought it was clear we had an understanding?"

" *What understanding, Bow."*

Bow shrugs. "I don't know. The thing were we hug but don't kiss. I thought hand-holding would be okay."

Glimmer's mouth falls open. "Kissing was on the table?"

"No, that was the whole point." Bow frowns. "Glimmer, are you okay?"

"No, no! I meant- was it on the *friend* table?"

Bow cocks his head, an unsure look crossing his face. "But… We're dating? Like. That was the understanding, right? You jumped over the fire with me during the victory celebrations and everything."

At Glimmer's uncomprehending face, he turns worried, if a little hurt. "Oh - okay. If you'd rather not-"

Glimmer's eyes widen and she shoots forward, capturing his hands in hers. "It's not about the dating! I didn't know but- I'd like to. Without the kissing, I mean. I just didn't know." She looks down at her feet. "I know I can be a little forceful but… you're supposed to tell me these things, okay? Don't just assume it's okay because I do it. Tell me when I'm crossing your boundaries."

Bow starts to beam, slowly, like the rising of the sun, like the breaking of the dawn through the clouds. "My boundaries with hugging and holding hands with you are *fully* `you ought to be

plastered against me always’ but good to know." Then his face turns sterner. "That said, the same counts for you. I’m always here for you to tell me stuff. Don’t just go panic all on your own."

Glimmer grins, bright and mischievous. "No, we panic together."

Holding hands, they walk through the fair together. Glimmer's been worried about candied apples all this time, sweet on the outside, sour within, when really, their relationship was her very own cotton candy all along.

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